



(LEFT) SHEIKH HASINA WAJED;
BANGLADESH ARMY TROOPS
SECURE DHAKA'S STREETS

seat. Besides, if the aftershocks of the mutiny linger, it could lead to skirmishes on the border, which could mean that terror groups planning attacks against India could easily cross over making use of the confusion in the ranks of the BDR and the Bangladesh Army. It will eventually lead to some trouble in the run up to the Lok Sabha elections in India.

Experts too warn that the situation

THE CLASHES IN DHAKA RAISE QUESTIONS ABOUT THE BANGLADESH RIFLES AND HOW IT COULD AFFECT SECURITY ON THE INDIA BORDER.

dier were dragged into Bangladeshi territory and brutally killed.

It was clearly an intelligence failure as the Bangladesh Army couldn't sense that a revolt was brewing. That it was not a spontaneous uprising but a well-planned one was apparent from the fact that the mutineers chose the morning meeting of the top brass of the BDR to start the shootings.

For India, that shares an over 4,096-km porous border with Bangladesh, the developments in Dhaka have a direct bearing on its own strategic interests as instability in its eastern neighbour can have an unpleasant fallout. While the BDR is crucial for addressing India's security concerns as it mans the border, dissatisfaction and clashes with the army would mean that the assurances to India that Bangladesh would safeguard India's security interests could take a back-

does not augur well for both neighbours. "Whenever there is a breakdown of discipline, the forces cannot perform their prime duty of guarding the border which may mean vulnerability for both Bangladesh and India. It is a worrying situation," says General Muniruzz Zaman, president of Bangladesh Institute of Peace and Security Studies, a Dhaka-based think tank. Indian analysts concur. "India needs to watch the situation carefully since the BDR patrols the Indo-Bangladesh border, and if this continues will it mean that the Bangladesh Army will become more powerful. This may not be the best scenario for India," says Veena Sikri, former Indian high commissioner to Bangladesh.

With growing fundamentalism and abject poverty, Bangladesh was turning into a haven for jihadi groups. This got an impetus during the pro-Islamist

government of Khaleda Zia, while the tide was turned by a caretaker army regime in the intermittent period. New Delhi was hoping that under Hasina's premiership things would change and there would be a clampdown on jihadi elements. India was also hoping to repair ties with the eastern neighbour, but that process may slow down.

Last month, during the visit of External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee to Dhaka, India had reinforced this message and sought some assurances on its security, but this may now remain only on paper. India is concerned about militant camps functioning from Bangladesh and has handed over a list of over 140 terror camps active in its territory. A growing worry for New Delhi is that Pakistan's intelligence agency ISI and terrorist groups such as Lashkar-e-Toiba and Harkat-ul-Jihad-al-Islami have been using Bangladesh to launch terror attacks against India. Even the trail of the 26/11 Mumbai attacks led to some individuals in Bangladesh and some suspects were also detained by the Bangladesh Government at India's request. India also fears that the ISI may use this dissension in the ranks of the Bangladeshi armed forces to fish in troubled waters.

India's worries are also compounded by the fact that almost half of the Indo-Bangla border is still not fenced and illegal immigration and smuggling is rampant. New Delhi would want the Hasina regime to address India's security concerns and not to get bogged down by issues concerning its own security forces. Besides, trouble at home would also reduce Hasina's ability to manoeuvre, which may also stymie any deal with India for the exchange of some top ULFA leaders, including Anup Chetia and Paresh Barua, who are in Bangladesh. While the crisis may blow over, the concern for India is that it may destabilise the new Government. Hasina may have already struck a deal with the rebel BDR troops, but it has also shown that her nascent regime is susceptible to blackmailing by various groups, including jihadi elements, which is bad news on India's eastern flank. ■